people in Cairo and Kuala Lumpur remain poor, because neither the profits nor the power is distributed back.

The nature of the new information economy might make the imbalance between imperial hub and exploited colony worse than ever. In ancient times land – rather than information – was the most important economic asset. This precluded the overconcentration of all wealth and power in a single hub. As long as land was paramount, considerable wealth and power always remained in the hands of provincial landowners. A Roman emperor, for example, could put down one provincial revolt after another, but on the day after decapitating the last rebel chief, he had no choice but to appoint a new set of provincial landowners who might again challenge the central power. In the Roman Empire, although Italy was the seat of political power, the richest provinces were in the eastern Mediterranean. It was impossible to transport the fertile fields of the Nile valley to the Italian peninsula.[19] Eventually the emperors abandoned the city of Rome to the barbarians and moved the seat of political power to the rich east, to Constantinople.

During the Industrial Revolution machines became more important than land. Factories, mines, railway lines and electrical power stations became the most valuable assets. It was somewhat easier to concentrate these kinds of assets in one place. The British Empire could centralise industrial production in its home islands, extract raw materials from India, Egypt and Iraq, and sell them finished goods made in Birmingham or Belfast. Unlike in the Roman Empire, Britain was the seat of both political and economic power. But physics and geology still put natural limits on this concentration of wealth and power. The British couldn’t move every cotton mill from Calcutta to Manchester, or shift the oil wells from Kirkuk to Yorkshire.

Information is different. Unlike cotton and oil, digital data can be sent from Malaysia or Egypt to Beijing or San Francisco at almost the speed of light. And unlike land, oil fields or textile factories, algorithms don’t take up much space. Consequently, unlike industrial power, the world’s algorithmic power *can* be concentrated in a single hub. Engineers in a single country might write the code and control the keys for all the crucial algorithms that run the entire world.

Indeed, AI makes it possible to concentrate in one place even the decisive assets of some traditional industries, like textiles. In the nineteenth century, to control the textile industry meant to control sprawling cotton fields and huge mechanical production lines. In the twenty-first century, the most